



Gold rush: The women's team of Harika Dronavalli, R. Vaishali, Divya Deshmukh, Vantika Agarwal and Tania Sachdev won gold at the 2024 FIDE Chess Olympiad in Hungary. FIDE/MICHAŁ WALUSZA

Mayank
Mayank.c@thehindu.co.in

When Ding Liren moved his rook to the f2 square in the 14th and final game of the 2024 World chess championship, it might have appeared to be just another ordinary move from the reigning and 17th World champion. However, for Indian chess, it symbolised a momentous high, the likes of which had not been seen in a long, long time. Leading this remarkable wave of success was none other than a teenager. On December 12, 2024, D. Gukesh realised his dream of becoming the youngest-ever World chess champion. In a dramatic turn of events, a one-move blunder by Ding — which could have otherwise led to tie-breaks — handed the crown to Gukesh in Singapore, making him the new king of the

chess world.

The 18-year-old Gukesh, who shattered Garry Kasparov's long-standing record to become the youngest World chess champion, spearheaded Indian chess in 2024, marking a historic year of unparalleled achievements.

The rise of Indian chess wasn't sudden. The seeds of this success had been sown over the years. From a shared gold in the 2020 Online Olympiad to a historic silver medal at the 2021 Women's Team Championship, a bronze medal in the Open section at the 2022 Chennai Olympiad, and R. Praggnanandhaa's run to the 2023 World Cup final — Indian chess had been steadily brewing a storm. With Vidit Gujrathi and R. Vaishali's Grand